

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2001-04-19

To an individual believer

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,

2 The principal issue raised in your letter is that of the timing for the oc-
3 currence of the lesser peace, in light of your impression that the bahá'í
4 writings anticipate its coming before the conclusion of the twentieth cen-
5 tury; i.e., the end of d ecember 2000.

enclosed for your information is a copy of a memorandum prepared by

6 the research department, at the request of the house of justice, on the
7 subject of the attainment of the unity of nations and the lesser peace. As-
8 sembled in this document are a number of pertinent passages from authori-
9 tative texts of the f aith.

10 in reviewing this material it becomes apparent that there is nothing in
11 the authoritative b ahá'í w ritings to indicate that the lesser p eace would be
12 established before the end of the twentieth century. however, there are clear
13 statements affirming that the unity of nations would be, in the words of 'Abdu'l-b
ahá, "securely established" during the twentieth century.

14 These statements, and others appearing in the enclosed document,

should be viewed from the perspective that the evolution of the world

15 order of bahá'u'lláh is an organic process proceeding in accordance with
16 the divine will and animated by a spiritual reality. in response to a ques-
17 tion, 'Abdu'l-b ahá wrote: "The kingdom of peace, salvation, uprightness,
18 and reconciliation is founded in the invisible world, and it will by degrees become
manifest and apparent through the power of the word of god!" As

19 a result of consecrated human endeavor over decades, and indeed centuries, this
spiritual reality is gradually expressed in physical form.

20 An orientation to process is apparent throughout the writings of 'Abdu'l-

21 bahá and Shoghi effendi concerning the attainment of world peace. for ex-
22 ample, the guardian reported the master as having acclaimed actions taken
23 at the conclusion of the first world war to have signalized “the dawn of the
24 most great peace.” This stands in contrast to preoccupation with the short
25 term in the wider society today which focuses exclusively on events rather
than on evolutionary processes.356.1

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357 2000–2001 • T h e T W e l v e m o n T h P l a n

358 78you should also take note of the distinction between the unity of na-
359 tions and the lesser peace. Shoghi effendi, in response to questions from
360 believers, clarified that “unity in the political realm,” to which ‘Abdu’l-b ahá
361 referred in his enunciation of the seven candles of unity, “is a unity which
362 politically independent and sovereign states achieve among themselves.” As
363 expressed in the passages cited in the enclosed memorandum, the lesser
364 peace will initially be a political unity arrived at by decision of the various
365 governments of the world. The unity of nations can be taken as that unity which
arises from a recognition among the peoples of the various nations, that they are members of
one common human family.

The twentieth century has been distinguished by the emergence of the

366 unity of nations, to which both Shoghi effendi and the house of justice
367 have referred in the enclosed document. This movement, the evidence of
368 which accumulates with each passing day, stands in sharp contrast to the
369 nationalistic tenor of the nineteenth century, and is an evidence of the spirit of a new
age moving in the hearts of humankind. viewed from this per-
370 spective, there can be no doubt that the promise of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá has been
371 fulfilled, and the unity of nations securely established in the century now concluded.
The further expansion and strengthening of this consciousness of world solidarity in the
years to come will have their effect in the political realm, and will influence the evolution
towards world government.

it should not be imagined that the processes now moving in the world

372 will be free from challenge or difficulty. There may well be setbacks, and conflicts
may erupt periodically, as humanity proceeds towards the emer-

373 gence and consolidation of the lesser peace, giving rise in due course to the

374 establishment of the most great peace.

375 with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the secretariat 356.6

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357 message from The Universal House of Justice

358 MEMORANDUM

19 April 2001

To the Universal House of Justice

from the research department

Attainment of the unity of Nations and the lesser peace

20 Introduction:

The bahá'í writings about world peace envisage the most great peace

21 coming as the culmination of two distinct processes which unfold gradu-

22 ally over a lengthy period. one of these processes concerns the growth and

23 development of the bahá'í community, with the evolution of the Adminis-

24 trative order and its efflorescence in the world order of bahá'u'lláh. The

25 other process, the subject of this memorandum, is associated with develop-ments in
the wider society, notably the attainment of the unity of nations

26 and the establishment of the lesser peace.

27 Unity of Nations and the Lesser Peace:

28 Shoghi effendi refers to bahá'u'lláh addressing "all the kings of the earth,

29 summoning them to cleave to the lesser peace, as distinct from that most

30 great peace which those who are fully conscious of the power of his revela-

31 tion and avowedly profess the tenets of his faith can alone proclaim and

must eventually establish. . . ."

32 356-1 in the words of bahá'u'lláh:

**Now that ye have refused the most great peace, hold ye fast unto
this, the lesser peace, that haply ye may in some degree better your
own condition and that of your dependents.**

**o rulers of the earth! be reconciled among yourselves, that ye may
need no more armaments save in a measure to safeguard your ter-
ritories and dominions. beware lest ye disregard the counsel of the
All-knowing, the faithful.**

**be united, o kings of the earth, for thereby will the tempest of
discord be stilled amongst you, and your peoples find rest, if ye be of them that
comprehend. Should anyone among you take up arms**

356-1. pdc, ¶58.356.9

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2000–2001 • The Twelve Month Plan

785against another, rise ye all against him, for this is naught but manifest

justice.356-2

in another passage, bahá'u'lláh has related the lesser peace to the gather-
ing together of world leaders at a convocation in which measures for unity
and concord would be devised.

**we pray god—exalted be his glory—and cherish the hope that
he may graciously assist the manifestations of affluence and power
and the daysprings of sovereignty and glory, the kings of the earth—
may god aid them through his strengthening grace—to establish**

the lesser peace. This, indeed, is the greatest means for insuring the
tranquillity of the nations. it is incumbent upon the Sovereigns of the
world—may god assist them—unitedly to hold fast unto this peace,
which is the chief instrument for the protection of all mankind. it

is our hope that they will arise to achieve what will be conducive

365 to the well-being of man. it is their duty to convene an all-inclusive

366 assembly, which either they themselves or their ministers will attend, and to enforce whatever measures are required to establish unity and concord amongst men. They must put away the weapons of war, and

turn to the instruments of universal reconstruction. Should one king

367 rise up against another, all the other kings must arise to deter him. Arms and armaments will, then, be no more needed beyond that which is necessary to insure the internal security of their respective

368 countries. if they attain unto this all-surpassing blessing, the people

of each nation will pursue, with tranquillity and contentment, their

own occupations, and the groanings and lamentations of most men

369 would be silenced.

370 356-3

371 The theme of a gathering to deliberate on the measures required for an

372 enduring world peace is referred to in several other places in the writings of

373 bahá'u'lláh, including:

The time must come when the imperative necessity for the holding of

374 a vast, an all-embracing assemblage of men will be universally realized.

375 356-2. pdc, ¶60-62.

376 356-3. eSw , pp. 30-31.356.11

356 11a

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356 12a

357 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

358 786The rulers and kings of the earth must needs attend it, and, participat-

ing in its deliberations, must consider such ways and means as will

lay the foundations of the world's great peace amongst men. Such a

peace demandeth that the great powers should resolve, for the sake

359 of the tranquillity of the peoples of the earth, to be fully reconciled

among themselves. Should any king take up arms against another, all

should unitedly arise and prevent him. if this be done, the nations

of the world will no longer require any armaments, except for the

360 purpose of preserving the security of their realms and of maintaining internal order
within their territories. This will ensure the peace and

361 composure of every people, government and nation.

362 356-4

Subsequently 'Abdu'l-b ahá specified one of the outcomes of this con-

363 vocation to be a comprehensive treaty, the provisions of which would be binding on
all governments:

T rue civilization will unfurl its banner in the midmost heart of

364 the world whenever a certain number of its distinguished and high-minded
sovereigns—the shining exemplars of devotion and determi-

365 nation—shall, for the good and happiness of all mankind, arise, with firm resolve and
clear vision, to establish the cause of universal peace.

They must make the cause of peace the object of general consulta-

tion, and seek by every means in their power to establish a union of

366 the nations of the world. They must conclude a binding treaty and establish a
covenant, the provisions of which shall be sound, invio-

lable and definite. They must proclaim it to all the world and obtain

367 for it the sanction of all the human race. This supreme and noble undertaking—the
real source of the peace and well-being of all the world—should be regarded as sacred by all
that dwell on earth. All

the forces of humanity must be mobilized to ensure the stability and

permanence of this most great covenant. in this all-embracing pact

368 the limits and frontiers of each and every nation should be clearly fixed, the
principles underlying the relations of governments towards

369 one another definitely laid down, and all international agreements and

obligations ascertained. in like manner, the size of the armaments of

370 356-4. gwb, no. 117 .1.356.13

356 13a

357 2000–2001 • T h e T W e l v e m o n T h P l a n

358 787every government should be strictly limited, for if the preparations

for war and the military forces of any nation should be allowed to increase, they will arouse the suspicion of others. The fundamental principle underlying this solemn pact should be so fixed that if any

359 government later violate any one of its provisions, all the governments on earth should arise to reduce it to utter submission, nay the human

360 race as a whole should resolve, with every power at its disposal, to de-

361 stroy that government. Should this greatest of all remedies be applied to the sick body of the world, it will assuredly recover from its ills and will remain eternally safe and secure.

362 356-5

363 distinct from, but closely related to, this theme is the promise by ‘Abdu’l-

364 bahá, both orally and in writing, that the unity of nations will be established

365 during the twentieth century, as an essential foundation for world peace.

366 in one of his talks, he stated:

i am most hopeful that in this century these lofty thoughts shall be

conducive to human welfare. let this century be the sun of previous

367 centuries, the effulgences of which shall last forever, so that in times

368 to come they shall glorify the twentieth century, saying the twentieth century was the century of lights, the twentieth century was the cen-

tury of life, the twentieth century was the century of international

369 peace. . . .

370 356-6

371 As was reported in the Montreal Daily Star newspaper:

“Are there any signs that the permanent peace of the world will be

established in anything like a reasonable period?” ‘Abdu’l-bahá was

372 asked. “it will be established in this century,” he answered. “it will

373 be universal in the twentieth century. All nations will be forced into

it.”356-7

374 356-5. wob, pp. 37–38.

375 356-6. pup, p. 174.

376 356-7. Abc, p. 35.356.14

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356 16a

357 m eS Sa g e S f r o m Th e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

358 788in commenting on other pronouncements of the master on this theme,

359 the house of justice stated the following in a letter written on its behalf on

29 july 1974:

it is true that ‘Abdu’l-b ahá made statements linking the establish-

30 ment of the unity of nations to the twentieth century. for example:

“The fifth candle is the unity of nations—a unity which, in this cen-

31 tury, will be securely established, causing all the peoples of the world to regard themselves as citizens of one common fatherland.” And, in *The Promised Day Is Come*, following a similar statement quoted from

Some Answered Questions, Shoghi effendi makes this comment: “This

is the stage which the world is now approaching, the stage of world

32 unity, which, as ‘Abdu’l-b ahá assures us, will, in this century, be se-

curely established.”

however, attainment of the unity of nations should not be regarded as

33 being synonymous with the establishment of the lesser peace. in answer to

34 a question about the timing of the lesser peace, Shoghi effendi stated, in

35 a letter written on his behalf in 1946, that: “All we know is that the lesser

peace and the most great peace will come—their exact dates we do not

know.”

36 356-8

37 Nevertheless, the unity of nations can quite properly be regarded as one

38 stage—and indeed a highly significant step—in the lengthy process of the

39 establishment of the lesser peace. in response to a question from an indi-

40 vidual, the house of justice stated, in a letter written on its behalf on 31

41 january 1985, that:

bahá'u'lláh's principal mission in appearing at this time in human

42 history is the realization of the oneness of mankind and the establish-ment of peace
among the nations; therefore, all the forces which are

focused on accomplishing these ends are influenced by his revela-

tion. we know, however, that peace will come in stages. first, there

43 will come the lesser peace, when the unity of nations will be achieved,

then gradually the most great peace—the spiritual as well as social

44 356-8. lg, no. 1425.356.17

356 17a

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356 19a

357 2000–2001 • T h e T W e l v e m o n T h P l a n

358 789and political unity of mankind, when the bahá'í world common-

359 wealth, operating in strict accordance with the laws and ordinances of

the most holy book of the bahá'í revelation, will have been estab-

360 lished through the efforts of the b ahá'ís.

As to the lesser peace, Shoghi effendi has explained that this will

361 initially be a political unity arrived at by decision of the governments of various
nations; it will not be established by direct action of the

362 bahá'í community. . . .

363 The lesser peace itself will pass through stages; at the initial stage

the governments will act entirely on their own without the conscious

364 involvement of the faith; later on, in god's good time, the faith will

365 have a direct influence on it in ways indicated by Shoghi effendi in his

"The goal of a New world order."

366 356-9

367 The progressive development of the lesser peace, including its consoli-

368 dation, is clarified by the statement of the guardian, in his letter of rixvân

105 b.e. to the friends in the east, concerning the duration of the forma-

106 tive Age:

**its duration is unknown and lies concealed within the treasury of
god's knowledge. its termination will coincide with the establishment**

of this most perfect, this most mighty order throughout the east

and the west, the resplendent emergence of organic unity among

107 the component parts of human society, and the consolidation of the foundations of
the lesser peace among the governments and nations

108 of the world.

109 further elaboration was provided by the house of justice when requested

110 by an individual believer to clarify the following passage from the 1996

111 riḫvān message:

however short the path to peace, it will be tortuous; however

112 promising the anticipated event that will set its course, it must mature through a long
period of evolution, with its attendant tests, setbacks

113 356-9. muhj, no. 422.356.19b

356 19c

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356 20a

356 21

356 21a

357 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

358 790and conflicts, towards the moment when it will have emerged, under

359 the direct influences of g o d ' s f a i t h , a s t h e m o s t g r e a t p e a c e .

360 in the letter of 29 july 1996 sent on its behalf in reply to that individual,

361 t h e h o u s e o f j u s t i c e w r o t e :

clearly, the emergence of the lesser peace will be a gradual process

362 and its various stages will no doubt witness tests and setbacks, as well as great
advances. it will certainly include, however, a development of

historic importance: that point at which the majority of the world's

nation-states formally commit themselves to a global order comprising

363 institutions and laws, and equipped with the means by which collec-tive decisions
can be enforced. while we cannot at present foresee the

364 precise form that this development will take, much less the point at which it will occur, we recognize that it is a feature of the process of the lesser peace.

with the emphasis being given in recent years to the comple-

tion of the present phase in the construction of the edifices of the

Administrative order on the slopes of mount carmel, some believ-

ers have enquired whether there is a causative relationship between

365 the accomplishment of this construction program and the establishment of the lesser peace. The Secretariat of the house of justice responded to one

366 such enquiry, in a letter of 14 december 1987, as follows:

it knows of nothing in the writings of the faith to indicate that the

establishment of the lesser peace depends on the completion of the

367 Arc on mount carmel.

The passage which may have given rise to this conception may

well be the statement made by the beloved guardian which is pub-

lished on pages 74–75 of Messages to the Bahá'í World. . . . you will

note that in this passage the guardian describes three things which

will synchronize. it is important to note that he is describing, not

events, but processes or developments and, although he says they will

synchronize—a statement which in itself provides important guid-

368 ance for the institutions of the cause—he does not state that they are

dependent one upon the other.356.22

356 22a

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356 23a

356 23b

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358 791The Events of the Twentieth Century:

it is useful to review some of the statements appearing in the bahá'í

359 writings concerning the events in the twentieth century which represent

360 stages in the progression of humanity towards the unity of nations and the
361 lesser peace. in 1931 Shoghi effendi characterizes the emergence of world
362 mindedness in the following terms:

363 To the states and principalities just emerging from the welter of the great Napoleonic
upheaval, whose chief preoccupation was either to recover their rights to an independent
existence or to achieve their

364 national unity, the conception of world solidarity seemed not only re-
365 mote but inconceivable. it was not until the forces of nationalism had

succeeded in overthrowing the foundations of the holy Alliance that

366 had sought to curb their rising power, that the possibility of a world order,
transcending in its range the political institutions these nations had established, came to be
seriously entertained. it was not until after

the world war that these exponents of arrogant nationalism came to

367 regard such an order as the object of a pernicious doctrine tending to sap that
essential loyalty upon which the continued existence of their national life depended.

368 356-10

369 A highly significant milestone in this process was the formation of the
370 league of Nations after the first world war, an event which was praised by
371 ‘Abdu’l-b ahá, despite his warning that:

372 . . . although the league of Nations has been brought into existence,

yet it is incapable of establishing universal peace.356-11

373 in the years leading up to the outbreak of the Second world war, Shoghi
374 effendi affirmed that:

375 Though the great outcry raised by post-war nationalism is growing louder and more
insistent every day, the league of Nations is as yet in

its embryonic state, and the storm clouds that are gathering may for

376 a time totally eclipse its powers and obliterate its machinery, yet the

377 356-10. wob, p. 44.

378 356-11. Sw Ab, no. 227 .31.356.24

356 24a

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356 25a

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356 26a
357 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
358 792direction in which the institution itself is operating is most significant.
359 The voices that have been raised ever since its inception, the efforts
360 that have been exerted, the work that has already been accomplished,
361 foreshadow the triumphs which this presently constituted institution, or any other
body that may supersede it, is destined to achieve.

362 356-12

he drew attention to “the most significant landmarks in its checkered

363 history,” outstanding among which was its decision to impose collective

sanctions upon a member which the league deemed to have committed an

364 act of aggression. Shoghi e f f e n d i pointed out that:

for the first time in the history of humanity the system of collec-

tive security, foreshadowed by bahá’u’lláh and explained by ‘Abdu’l-

365 bahá, has been seriously envisaged, discussed and tested. for the first

time in history it has been officially recognized and publicly stated

366 that for this system of collective security to be effectively established

strength and elasticity are both essential—strength involving the use

367 of an adequate force to ensure the efficacy of the proposed system, and elasticity to
enable the machinery that has been devised to meet

the legitimate needs and aspirations of its aggrieved upholders. for

368 the first time in human history tentative efforts have been exerted by

369 the nations of the world to assume collective responsibility, and to supplement their
verbal pledges by actual preparation for collective

370 action. And again, for the first time in history, a movement of public

371 opinion has manifested itself in support of the verdict which the lead-ers and
representatives of nations have pronounced, and for securing collective action in pursuance
of such a decision.

372 356-13

373 his vision of the significance of this action was not obscured by the appar-

374 ent failure of the collective sanctions to accomplish their stated objective.

375 Shoghi effendi affirmed that the goal of the process by which the league
376 of Nations was established was that of attainment to "... the stage at which
377 the oneness of the whole body of nations will be made the ruling principle of
international life."

378 356-14

379 356-12. wob, p. 191.

380 356-13. wob, pp. 191-92. 356-14. wob, p. 193. 356.27

356 27a

356 28

357 2000-2001 • The Twelve on The Plan

358 He elaborated on the details of this process some two decades later in
359 1947, when the United Nations organization had replaced the League of
360 Nations and was itself proceeding along the path of development of its
361 powers and functions, with his anticipation that this process:

... must, however long and tortuous the way, lead, through a series

362 of victories and reverses, to the political unification of the eastern and

western hemispheres, to the emergence of a world government and

the establishment of the lesser peace, as foretold by bahá'u'lláh and

foreshadowed by the prophet Isaiah. 356-15

363 distinct from, but closely related to, this process of organizational devel-

364 opment has been the emergence of a world consciousness. As long ago as 1931, the Guardian referred to:

365 "... the gradual diffusion of the spirit of world solidarity which is

366 spontaneously arising out of the welter of a disorganized society.

367 356-16

368 one decade later, he commented that:

The world is, in truth, moving on towards its destiny. The inter-

369 dependence of the peoples and nations of the earth, whatever the leaders of the
divisive forces of the world may say or do, is already an accomplished fact. Its unity in the
economic sphere is now understood

370 and recognized.

371 356-17

As humanity was plunged into a world war which Shoghi effendi de-

372 scribed as “the titanic upheaval foreshadowed seventy years ago by the
373 prophetic pen of bahá’u’lláh” and as the “long-predicted world-encircling
374 conflagration,” he pointed out to the bahá’ís that this great conflict was an

“essential prerequisite to world unification.”356-18

375 356-15. cf , p. 33.

376 356-16. wob, p. 44.

377 356-17 . pdc, p. 200.356-18. muhj, no. 438.1–7 . 356.29

356 29a

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356 30a

356 31

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357 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

358 79Recent Developments:

359 in recent years, the house of justice has taken the opportunity provided

360 by its rixvân messages to draw the attention of the worldwide bahá’í com-

361 munity to the profound significance of the events occurring in the wider

362 society as humanity exhibits a growing consciousness of the unity of the nations and
peoples of the planet.

363 particularly significant are the following passages taken from the october

364 1985 statement The Promise of World Peace addressed to the peoples of the

365 world:

Among the favorable signs are the steadily growing strength of the

366 steps towards world order taken initially near the beginning of this century in the
creation of the league of Nations, succeeded by the

more broadly based united Nations organization; the achievement

since the Second world war of independence by the majority of all

367 the nations on earth, indicating the completion of the process of nation building, and
the involvement of these fledgling nations with

older ones in matters of mutual concern; the consequent vast increase

368 in cooperation among hitherto isolated and antagonistic peoples and groups in
international undertakings in the scientific, educational, legal, economic and cultural fields;
the rise in recent decades of an

369 unprecedented number of international humanitarian organizations;

370 the spread of women's and youth movements calling for an end to war; and the
spontaneous spawning of widening networks of ordinary

371 people seeking understanding through personal communication.

372 356-19

The tentative steps towards world order, especially since world war

373 ii, give hopeful signs. The increasing tendency of groups of nations to formalize
relationships which enable them to cooperate in matters

374 of mutual interest suggests that eventually all nations could overcome this paralysis.
The Association of South east Asian Nations, the ca-

ribbean community and common market, the central American

common market, the council for mutual economic Assistance, the

European communities, the league of Arab States, the organization

of African unity, the organization of American States, the South

375 356-19. muj, no. 438.1-7 .356.33

356 34

356 34a

356 34b

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358 795pacific forum—all the joint endeavors represented by such organiza-

tions prepare the path to world order.356-20

359 The army of men and women, drawn from virtually every culture,

race and nation on earth, who serve the multifarious agencies of the

United Nations, represent a planetary "civil service" whose impres-

sive accomplishments are indicative of the degree of cooperation that

360 can be attained even under discouraging conditions. An urge towards unity, like a
spiritual springtime, struggles to express itself through

countless international congresses that bring together people from a

361 vast array of disciplines. it motivates appeals for international projects

362 involving children and youth. indeed, it is the real source of the re-

markable movement towards ecumenism by which members of histor-

363 ically antagonistic religions and sects seem irresistibly drawn towards

364 one another. Together with the opposing tendency to warfare and
self-aggrandizement against which it ceaselessly struggles, the drive

365 towards world unity is one of the dominant, pervasive features of life

366 on the planet during the closing years of the twentieth century.

367 356-21

368 The pace of change accelerated as the twentieth century approached its

369 conclusion. in 1996 the house of justice wrote:

370 . . . world leaders are often taking collective actions that, to a bahá'í

371 observer, signify a tendency towards a common approach by nations to solving
world problems. consider, for instance, the unusual fre-

372 quency of the global occasions on which these leaders have gathered since the holy
year four years ago, such as the one in observance of

373 the fiftieth Anniversary of the united Nations, at which the attending

heads of state and heads of government asserted their commitment

to world peace. Noteworthy, too, are the promptitude and spontane-

374 ity with which these government leaders have been acting together in responding to
a variety of crises in different parts of the world.

375 Such trends coincide with the increasing cries from enlightened circles

for attention to be given to the feasibility of achieving some form

376 356-20. muhj, no. 438.25-28.

377 356-21. muhj, no. 438.54-55.356.34c

356 35

356 35a

357 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

358 796of global governance. might we not see in these swiftly developing

**occurrences the workings of the hand of providence, indeed the very
harbinger of the monumental occasion forecast in our writings?**³⁵⁶⁻²²

³⁵⁹ while in 1998 it commented that:

³⁶⁰ . . . amid the din of a society in turmoil can be discerned an unmistak-

³⁶¹ able trend towards the lesser peace. An intriguing inkling is provided

by the greater involvement of the united Nations, with the backing

of powerful governments, in attending to long-standing and urgent

world problems; another derives from the dramatic recognition by

³⁶² world leaders in only recent months of what the interconnectedness of all nations in
the matter of trade and finance really implies—a condition which Shoghi effendi anticipated
as an essential aspect of

³⁶³ an organically unified world.

³⁶⁴ 356-23

reviewing the significant events which occurred in the world over the

³⁶⁵ past four years, the house of justice stated at riḡvān 2000 that “world

³⁶⁶ leaders took bold steps towards fashioning the structures of a global political peace”
and that:

. . . attempts at implementing and elaborating the methods of col-

lective security were earnestly made, bringing to mind one of

³⁶⁷ bahá’u’lláh’s prescriptions for maintaining peace; a call was raised for

³⁶⁸ an international criminal court to be established, another action that accords with
bahá’í expectations; to focus attention on the imperative

³⁶⁹ need for an adequate system to deal with global issues, world leaders are scheduled
to meet in a millennium Summit; new methods of com-

munications have opened the way for everyone to communicate with

³⁷⁰ anyone on the planet.

³⁷¹ 356-24

A few months later, in reporting on millennial gatherings held in New

³⁷² york during the year 2000 to address global issues pertaining to peace—the

³⁷³ 356-22. See no. 216, pp. 480–95, riḡvān message 153 b.e.

³⁷⁴ 356-23. See no. 263, pp. 612–17, riḡvān message 155 b.e.356-24. See no. 331, pp.
716–29, 2000 riḡvān message.356.36

356 36a

356 37

356 37a

356 38

357 2000–2001 • The Twelve Month Plan

358 797millennium forum in may, the millennium peace Summit of religious and

Spiritual leaders in August, and the millennium Summit of the leaders

of more than 150 nations held in September—the house of justice com-

359 mented, in its message of 24 September 2000, that:

for any observer imbued with the bahá'í vision of peace and its

inherent processes, the substance and implications of these recent

360 events, seen together with previous world conferences that during the last decade
also involved leaders of nations, must be gratifying indeed to contemplate. it must, too, be
doubly thrilling to realize that at so

early a stage in the bahá'í era, representatives of our international

361 community took part so notably in these occurrences that have set down milestones
along the way towards that new world order so

362 clearly foreshadowed by the pen of bahá'u'lláh.

363 357

Riḍván Message 2001

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]